

Georgia



Area 26,911 sq miles
(69,700 sq km)
Population 4.3 million
Capital Tbilisi
Currency Lari
Official languages Georgian,
Abkhazian (in Abkhazia)
Life expectancy 71 years

A mountainous country, Georgia is sandwiched between the Greater and Lesser Caucasus mountains. It was one of the first countries to demand independence from the Soviet Union (USSR), in 1991. Georgia is famous for its traditional wine industry.

Azerbaijan



Area 33,436 sq miles
(86,600 sq km)
Population 9.3 million
Capital Baku
Currency New manat
Official language Azeri
Life expectancy 72 years

Located on the west coast of the Caspian Sea, Azerbaijan was the first Soviet republic to declare independence. The Azeri people, who make up about 91 percent of the population, are Shi'a Muslims with close ethnic links to the Turks. Azerbaijan's economy is now growing, thanks to its vast oil wealth from the Caspian Sea oil fields.

Israel



Area 8,019 sq miles
(20,770 sq km)
Population 7.6 million
Capital Jerusalem
Currency Sheqalim
Official languages Hebrew
and Arabic
Life expectancy 80 years

The world's only nation with a majority Jewish population, the State of Israel was created in 1948. Since then, it has been in conflict with Palestine and neighboring Arab countries over territory that is considered holy by the Jews, Christians, and Muslims. Israel has a modern infrastructure and a sophisticated, high-tech economy.



▲ KHACHAPURI

A traditional dish from Georgia, khachapuri is stuffed bread. The filling contains cheese, and sometimes eggs or meat.

Syria



Area 71,112 sq miles
(184,180 sq km)
Population 20.8 million
Capital Damascus
Currency Syrian pound
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 74 years

Located in Western Asia, the Syrian Arab Republic is bordered by Lebanon and the Mediterranean Sea in the west and Iraq in the east. Syria has been under a military-backed regime for almost four decades. In 2011, street protests broke out, demanding political and economic changes. Tensions have now escalated into civil war.

Jordan



Area 35,637 sq miles
(92,300 sq km)
Population 6.3 million
Capital Amman
Currency Jordanian dinar
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 72 years

The Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan is surrounded by the deserts of the Middle East. The vast majority of its population lives in the northwest, on the east bank of the River Jordan. Jordan is headed by a king, though multiparty elections were introduced in 1993. It is a predominantly Muslim country with Bedouin roots.

Armenia



Area 11,506 sq miles
(29,800 sq km)
Population 3.1 million
Capital Yerevan
Currency Dram
Official language Armenian
Life expectancy 72 years

Armenia is a landlocked nation in the Lesser Caucasus Mountains. It was the first country to adopt Christianity as its state religion, in the 4th century. Armenia has been a multiparty democracy since its independence from the USSR in 1991.

Lebanon



Area 4,015 sq miles
(10,400 sq km)
Population 4.3 million
Capital Beirut
Currency Lebanese pound
Official language Arabic
Life expectancy 72 years

The Republic of Lebanon has a Mediterranean coast and shares borders with Syria and Israel. Once the commercial hub of the Middle East, Lebanon has been affected by regional conflicts, as well as a war with Israel in 2006. Lebanon has tried to regain its healthy economy with its growing tourism and strong financial services sector.



▲ PETRA

Jordan's most visited tourist attraction, Petra is an ancient Arabian city famous for its rock-cut architecture.

